

Mexican Taqueria

Masa, fire, fat, acid. Four things. Done right.

32	\$26	21%	\$13.8K
SEATS	AVG SPEND	FOOD COST	EST. MONTHLY NET

// WHAT A MICHELIN-TRAINED CHEF SEES IN MEXICAN TAQUERIA COOKING

Mexican street food is built on four elements: masa, fire, fat and acid. The tortilla must be pressed from masa harina and cooked on a comal — not a flat-top, not a skillet, a comal. The char marks matter. The al pastor requires an actual vertical spit or a close approximation — the caramelisation from the rotating fat drip is the flavour. Carnitas at 21% food cost works because pork shoulder is cheap and the lard-braising method converts a tough, inexpensive cut into something that pulls apart and crisps in the pan in 90 seconds. The taqueria format succeeds commercially because the food costs are among the lowest of any cuisine category while the perceived value is high — two tacos at \$4 each feel like a deal at \$8 and cost \$1.70 to produce.

// WHAT THIS GUIDE DOES

The US taqueria market is experiencing a quality shift. The customer who grew up eating Taco Bell now knows what a proper taco is — and they're willing to pay for it. Authentic masa. Proper al pastor. A salsa verde made with tomatillos, not green dye. The \$26 average spend at 32 covers in a lean operation produces the kind of monthly net that surprises first-time operators. Low labour. High volume. Fast tickets.

This guide is the operating manual for doing it right.

SECTION 1 — ENTRÉES

Dish	Ticket	Price	FC%
Chips & Salsa Trio — Verde, Roja, Habanero	2 min	\$6.99	9%

Guacamole — Table Side	3 min	\$8.99	18%
Elotes — Mexican Street Corn	5 min	\$5.99	11%
Queso Fundido — Melted Cheese, Chorizo	6 min	\$9.99	16%
Ceviche Tostada — Shrimp, Avocado	5 min	\$9.99	20%
Sopa de Lima — Yucatan Lime Chicken Soup	5 min	\$7.99	14%

Chips & Salsa Trio

Chips & Salsa Trio — Verde, Roja, Habanero

2 min ticket · FC: 9% · \$6.99 · Best margin starter

Ingredient	Qty (batch)	Cost/portion
Corn tortillas, fried in-house	8 chips	\$0.20
Salsa verde (tomatillo, jalapeño, cilantro)	60ml	\$0.15
Salsa roja (roasted tomato, chipotle)	60ml	\$0.12
Habanero salsa	30ml	\$0.16

\$0.63 **\$6.99** **9%** **\$6.36**

FOOD COSTMENU PRICEFC%GROSS PROFIT

Fry tortilla chips in-house — it takes 3 minutes and they're dramatically better than bagged. Salsas batch-made daily. This starter has the best margin on the menu — push it at every table.

SECTION 2 — MAINS

Dish	Price	FC%	Note
Al Pastor Tacos 2pc — Pineapple, Onion, Cilantro	\$10.99	20%	Signature
Carnitas Tacos 2pc — Crispy Pork, Salsa Verde	\$10.99	19%	Signature
Carne Asada Tacos 2pc	\$12.99	22%	
Fish Tacos 2pc — Baja Batter, Slaw	\$11.99	21%	
Birria Tacos 2pc — Consommé Dip	\$13.99	22%	Signature
Veggie Tacos 2pc — Roast Cauliflower, Black Bean	\$9.99	14%	Vegan
Taco Platter — 4 Tacos, Beans, Rice	\$18.99	21%	
Burrito — Choice of Protein	\$14.99	20%	
Quesadilla — Oaxacan Cheese + Protein	\$13.99	18%	
Torta — Mexican Sandwich, Telera Roll	\$13.99	19%	

Al Pastor Tacos

Al Pastor Tacos 2pc — Vertical Spit, Pineapple

8 min ticket · FC: 20% · \$10.99 · SIGNATURE

Ingredient	Qty (2 tacos)	Cost
Pork shoulder, marinated al pastor	100g	\$0.70
Corn tortillas, double-stacked	4 small	\$0.30
Pineapple, fresh slice + dice	30g	\$0.15
White onion, fine dice	20g	\$0.05
Cilantro, rough chop	5g	\$0.03
Salsa roja + lime	30ml / half	\$0.15

- 1 Al pastor marinade (batch): guajillo, ancho, chipotle chiles rehydrated and blended with achiote, pineapple juice, cumin, oregano, vinegar, garlic. Marinate sliced pork 24hr minimum.
- 2 Cook on vertical spit or — if no spit — layer in cast iron, cook in batches on high heat to develop caramelisation on edges. The char from the spit drip is the flavour. Don't skip the high heat.
- 3 Warm corn tortillas on comal both sides — 30 seconds each. Double-stack two tortillas per taco.
- 4 Top: al pastor, diced pineapple, white onion, cilantro. Salsa roja on side. Lime wedge. Serve immediately — corn tortillas dry fast.

The double tortilla is non-negotiable for street-style tacos — the single tortilla tears under the filling. Corn tortillas heated directly on the comal have a completely different texture to steamed.

Carnitas Tacos

Carnitas Tacos 2pc — Lard-Braised, Crisped

6 min ticket (batch prep) · FC: 19% · \$10.99 · SIGNATURE

Ingredient	Qty	Cost
Pork shoulder, cubed	120g pulled	\$0.75
Lard (braising medium)	shared batch cost	\$0.25
Orange, Coke, garlic, bay, cumin	aromatics	\$0.10
Corn tortillas x4 (double-stack x2)	4 small	\$0.30
Salsa verde, onion, cilantro, lime	—	\$0.23

- 1 Batch carnitas: cube pork shoulder. Submerge in lard with orange halves, Coke, garlic, bay, cumin. Cook at 160°C for 2.5 hours until tender. Cool in fat.

2 To order: portion 120g carnitas into hot dry pan. Press down. Let it crisp on one side — 90 seconds. Flip once. You want crispy exterior, tender inside.

3 Load on warm double-stacked corn tortillas with salsa verde, onion, cilantro. Lime on side.

Carnitas is one of the best food-cost proteins in Mexican cooking — pork shoulder is cheap, lard can be reused 2-3 times, and batch cooking means service is 90 seconds per order.

SECTION 3 — DESSERTS

Dish	Price	FC%
Churros — Cinnamon Sugar, Chocolate	\$7.99	12%
Tres Leches Cake	\$7.99	11%
Mango Sorbet — Chile Rim	\$5.99	10%
Flan — Cajeta (Goat Milk Caramel)	\$6.99	9%

SECTION 4 — DRINKS

Frozen Margarita — House

\$11.99 · Blanco tequila, lime, salt

Michelada

\$9.99 · Beer, lime, Clamato, Tajín

Agua Fresca — Jamaica

\$3.99 · Hibiscus, sugar, water

Horchata

\$3.99 · Rice, cinnamon, vanilla

Modelo Especial

\$6.99

Tamarind Soda

\$3.99

Spicy Mezcal Paloma

\$13.99 · Mezcal, grapefruit, jalapeño

Mexican Hot Chocolate

\$5.99 · Ibarra chocolate, cinnamon

SECTION 5 — SERVICE TRAINING

SCRIPT 01 — WELCOME + CHIP SALSA PUSH

"The chips are fried in-house — corn tortillas, this morning. The salsa trio is verde, roja and habanero. The habanero is genuinely hot. The verde is the one for the tacos. Start with that."

SCRIPT 02 — AL PASTOR STORY

"The al pastor has been marinating since yesterday — guajillo chiles, achiote, pineapple. It's the most important taco on the menu. The pineapple isn't garnish — it's part of the flavour balance. Don't skip it."

SCRIPT 03 — BIRRIA TACO + CONSOMMÉ

"The birria tacos come with consommé — the braising liquid the beef cooked in. You dip the taco before you eat it. It's messy. That's the point."

SCRIPT 04 — MARGARITA + MEZCAL OPTION

"The house margarita is blanco tequila, fresh lime, triple sec. If you want something smokier, the mezcal paloma — mezcal, fresh grapefruit, jalapeño. \$13.99. Very good with the carnitas."

SCRIPT 05 — RETURN VISIT

"The taco special changes weekly — whatever protein we're working with. Worth coming back. Tuesday is the best day — quieter, and the al pastor has been going since Sunday."

SECTION 6 — DAILY PREP SCHEDULE

Time	Task	Who
08:00	Carnitas batch into lard, salsa trio prepped	Chef
09:00	Al pastor carved/portioned, tortillas prepped	Chef
10:00	Rice, beans, guac base, fresh limes cut	Prep
11:00	Comal on, chip fryer ready	Chef
11:30	Lunch service opens	All
15:00	Reset, restock salsas, birria braise if needed	Chef

17:00	Dinner mise en place	All
22:00	Close, stock count, marinate next day's al pastor	Closer

SECTION 7 — P&L MODEL

Revenue	Daily	Weekly	Monthly
Food Sales (tacos, mains)	\$920	\$5,520	\$23,920
Beverage (margaritas, beer, aguas)	\$320	\$1,920	\$8,320
Total	\$1,240	\$7,440	\$32,240

Cost	%	Monthly
Food Cost	21%	\$6,770
Labour	28%	\$9,027
Overheads	15%	\$4,836
NET PROFIT	36%	\$11,607

The taqueria format has the best labour efficiency of any casual dining model. Two people can run a 32-seat room. The chips and salsa at 9% FC pays for itself in the first 10 tables.

SECTION 8 — SAFETY & ALLERGENS

Temperature Control		
Item	Hold Temp	Max Hold
Carnitas (cooked in lard)	Below 3°C in fat	5 days
Al pastor (raw marinated)	Below 3°C	48 hours
Salsas (fresh)	Below 4°C	3 days
Birria consommé	Above 65°C service	3 days refrigerated
Guacamole (with lime)	Below 4°C, covered	Same day only

Allergen Matrix	
Dish	Allergens
Al Pastor Tacos	None major
Fish Tacos	Fish Gluten

Quesadilla

Gluten

Dairy

Burrito

Gluten

Churros

Gluten

Eggs

Tres Leches

Gluten

Dairy

Eggs

Flan

Dairy

Eggs

Ceviche Tostada

Shellfish

Gluten